

THE SPIRITUAL BODY IN THE IMAGE OF THE EARTHLY BODY

A Biblical and Theological Study of Bodily Continuity in the Resurrection of Jesus Christ

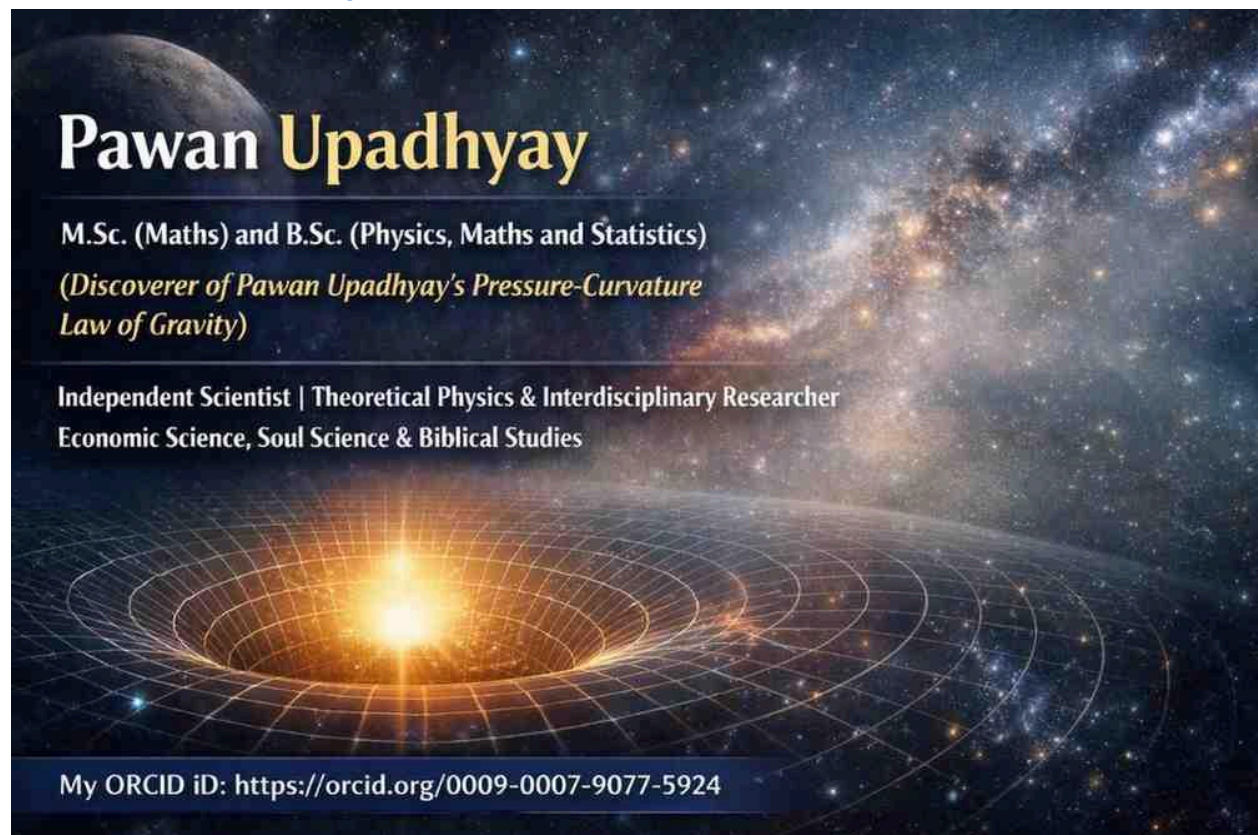
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ABSTRACT

This research paper examines the theological proposition that **the spiritual body is in the image or likeness of the earthly body**, particularly in relation to the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

The study focuses primarily on Paul's teaching in 1 Corinthians 15:44–49, especially the expression **σῶμα πνευματικόν** (*sōma pneumatikon*), meaning “spiritual body,” and Paul's statement concerning the “image of the earthly” and the “image of the heavenly.” The resurrection narratives in Luke 24 and John 20 are also examined because they present the risen Jesus as continuous in personal and bodily identity with the Jesus who was crucified.

This paper develops **Pawan Upadhyay's proposed theological model**, according to which the physical death of Jesus affected His earthly body, while His Divine Spirit remained alive. The model further proposes that His spiritual existence may be conceptualized in terms of a spiritual body corresponding to, or being in the image of, His earthly body. The resurrection is then understood as the restoration, reunification, and glorification of Christ's earthly bodily existence with His continuing Divine life.

The study carefully distinguishes explicit biblical teaching from theological interpretation. Scripture explicitly teaches the death, burial, resurrection, bodily appearances, and glorification of Jesus Christ and explicitly uses the expression “spiritual body.” However, Scripture does not explicitly state in technical terms that Jesus possessed a separate spiritual body during the interval between His death and resurrection. That particular proposition is therefore presented as a theological hypothesis rather than as a direct biblical statement.

The central thesis is that the biblical resurrection texts provide a strong conceptual foundation for **continuity together with transformation**, while the specific proposition that the spiritual body is in the image of the earthly body represents a theological synthesis developed within this research.

Keywords: Jesus Christ, resurrection, spiritual body, earthly body, Divine Spirit, σῶμα πνευματικόν, *sōma pneumatikon*, image, likeness, resurrection body, Christology, bodily continuity.

1. INTRODUCTION

The resurrection of Jesus Christ is at the center of Christian faith and theology.

The apostle Paul summarizes the fundamental Christian proclamation:

“Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, and that He was buried, and that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:3–4

The basic sequence is therefore:

Death → Burial → Resurrection

Yet an important theological question remains:

What is the relationship between the earthly body that died and the spiritual or resurrected body associated with Christ's resurrection?

This paper investigates that question through the following proposition:

The spiritual body is in the image or likeness of the earthly body.

This proposition forms an additional component of a broader resurrection model developed by the author.

The model seeks to understand Christ's resurrection through the relationship of three dimensions:

1. Divine Spirit
2. Spiritual Body
3. Earthly Body

The proposed relationship can be represented as:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body → Resurrected Christ

The purpose of this research is to examine the biblical foundations and theological implications of this model while maintaining a clear distinction between biblical statements and theological hypotheses.

2. RESEARCH QUESTION

The principal research question is:

Can the biblical concept of the spiritual body be understood as corresponding to the earthly body in such a way that personal and bodily identity remain continuous through death and resurrection?

Several subsidiary questions follow:

1. What does Paul mean by **σῶμα πνευματικόν** (*sōma pneumatikon*), “spiritual body”?
 2. Does “spiritual body” mean a bodyless spirit?
 3. What does Paul mean by the “image of the earthly” and “image of the heavenly”?
 4. What relationship exists between the crucified body and the resurrected body of Jesus?
 5. Do the resurrection narratives demonstrate bodily continuity?
 6. Can the concept of a spiritual body provide a theological explanation for continuity during physical death?
 7. Which parts of the proposed model are explicitly biblical, and which are theological interpretations?
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3. METHODOLOGY

This research employs four complementary approaches.

3.1 Biblical-Textual Analysis

Relevant passages of the New Testament are examined in their literary and theological contexts, especially:

- 1 Corinthians 15
- Luke 24
- John 20
- Acts 2
- 1 Peter 3
- Ephesians 4

3.2 Greek Lexical Analysis

Important Greek terms are examined to clarify the terminology used by the New Testament writers.

3.3 Theological Synthesis

The concepts of death, body, spirit, resurrection, image, transformation, and glorification are considered together.

3.4 Theological Model Construction

A conceptual model is developed while distinguishing:

Explicit Biblical Teaching

from

Theological Interpretation or Hypothesis.

This distinction is essential for responsible theological research.

4. THE GREEK CONCEPT OF “BODY”

The principal Greek word for “body” is:

σῶμα — *sōma*

Basic meanings include:

- body
- bodily existence
- corporeal form
- physical organism

Paul uses this word in 1 Corinthians 15:44:

σπείρεται σῶμα ψυχικόν, ἐγείρεται σῶμα πνευματικόν

Speiretai sōma psychikon, egeiretai sōma pneumatikon.

Meaning:

“It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.”

The same noun, **σῶμα**, appears in both descriptions.

The structure is therefore:

σῶμα → σῶμα

or:

Body → Body

while the mode or condition changes:

Natural → Spiritual

This is important because Paul does not simply describe:

Body → No Body

Rather, he speaks of transformation from one type or mode of bodily existence to another.

5. THE MEANING OF “SPIRITUAL BODY”

The Greek expression is:

σῶμα πνευματικόν

- sōma pneumatikon *

Meaning:

spiritual body

The adjective:

πνευματικός — *pneumatikos*

means “spiritual” or “pertaining to the spirit.”

The noun:

πνεῦμα — *pneuma*

can mean:

- spirit
- breath
- wind
- spiritual being
- Spirit

depending upon context.

Therefore, “spiritual body” should not automatically be interpreted as “bodyless spirit.”

The grammatical expression is:

Spiritual + Body

rather than:

Spirit = No Body

This distinction is fundamental to the present study.

6. RESURRECTION TERMINOLOGY

The principal Greek noun for resurrection is:

ἀνάστασις — *anastasis*

Meaning:

- rising
- standing up
- resurrection
- rising from the dead

A related verb is:

ἀνίστημι — *anistēmi*

meaning:

- to rise
- to stand up
- to raise

Another major resurrection verb is:

ἐγείρω — *egeirō*

meaning:

- to raise
- to raise up
- to awaken
- to cause to rise

These terms emphasize the movement from death toward life.

Therefore:

Resurrection = Rising from Death

rather than merely:

Continuation of Spiritual Consciousness

7. THE CENTRAL TEXT: 1 CORINTHIANS 15:44

Paul writes:

“It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.”

The Greek structure is:

σῶμα ψυχικόν → σῶμα πνευματικόν

Natural body → Spiritual body

The same noun **σῶμα** occurs on both sides.

This gives the passage an important structural continuity:

Body → Body

with transformation:

Natural → Spiritual

The passage therefore provides an important theological basis for understanding resurrection as transformed bodily existence.

However, 1 Corinthians 15:44 by itself does not establish that Jesus possessed a separate spiritual body during the interval between His physical death and resurrection. That further proposition belongs to the theological model developed in this paper.

8. THE IMAGE OF THE EARTHLY AND THE HEAVENLY

Paul states in 1 Corinthians 15:49:

“As we have borne the image of the earthly, we shall also bear the image of the heavenly.”

The Greek word for “image” is:

εἰκών — *eikōn*

Its semantic range includes:

- image
- likeness
- representation
- correspondence

Paul therefore establishes a relationship between:

Image of the Earthly

and:

Image of the Heavenly

The conceptual movement is:

Earthly Image → Heavenly Image

This provides an important conceptual foundation for the present research.

The person does not cease to exist as the same person. Rather, the person's condition is transformed.

Therefore:

Identity + Transformation

is more consistent with Paul's resurrection argument than:

Identity → Replacement

9. THE SPIRITUAL BODY AS CORRESPONDING TO THE EARTHLY BODY

The central hypothesis of this research can be expressed:

Spiritual Body ~ Earthly Body

where “~” represents:

- image
- likeness
- correspondence
- continuity

The proposition does not necessarily mean that the spiritual body possesses every physical property of the earthly body.

Rather, the proposed relationship concerns:

1. Personal identity
2. Bodily identity
3. Recognizable continuity
4. Structural correspondence
5. Transformation of bodily existence

Thus:

Same Person + Bodily Correspondence + Transformed Mode

The spiritual body, within this model, represents continuity rather than replacement of personal identity.

10. JESUS CHRIST AND BODILY CONTINUITY

The resurrection narratives provide important evidence concerning the identity of the risen Jesus.

The basic sequence is:

Jesus dies → Jesus is buried → Jesus is raised → Jesus appears

The person who appears after the resurrection is presented as the same Jesus who was crucified.

This establishes an important theological principle:

The resurrected Jesus is not a replacement for the crucified Jesus.

Rather:

Crucified Christ = Risen Christ

in personal identity, while:

Earthly Condition → Glorified Resurrection Condition

in bodily state.

11. LUKE 24:39 — FLESH AND BONES

In Luke 24:39, Jesus says:

“A spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.”

This statement is important because Jesus distinguishes His risen bodily existence from that of a merely disembodied spirit.

The resurrection narrative therefore presents Jesus as possessing genuine bodily reality.

The conceptual sequence is:

Death → Resurrection → Bodily Existence

Therefore:

Risen Jesus ≠ Merely Disembodied Spirit

The passage strongly supports bodily continuity in the Gospel's presentation of resurrection.

12. JESUS EATS AFTER THE RESURRECTION

Luke 24 also describes Jesus eating before His disciples.

The theological importance of this action is not necessarily that eating is required for resurrection existence.

Rather, it functions within the narrative to demonstrate that Jesus is not merely an incorporeal apparition.

Thus:

Resurrected Christ ≠ Mere Apparition

The resurrection body is presented as genuinely embodied.

13. THOMAS AND THE WOUNDS OF JESUS

John 20:27 records Jesus inviting Thomas to examine the wounds associated with His crucifixion.

The wounds serve as evidence of continuity between:

Crucified Jesus

and:

Risen Jesus

The risen Jesus is recognizable as the Jesus who was crucified.

Therefore:

Crucified Identity = Resurrected Identity

while:

Bodily Condition = Transformed

This distinction is central to the image-and-likeness principle.

14. RESURRECTION AS CONTINUITY AND TRANSFORMATION

Paul's resurrection argument contains several transformations:

Perishable → Imperishable

Dishonor → Glory

Weakness → Power

Natural → Spiritual

The pattern can therefore be summarized:

Transformation without loss of identity

This provides an important theological foundation for understanding the spiritual body as corresponding to the earthly body.

The body is transformed, but the identity of the person is preserved.

15. THE EMPTY TOMB

The empty tomb is significant for the doctrine of bodily resurrection.

If resurrection meant only spiritual survival, the physical body could remain in the grave.

However, the Gospel narratives proclaim an empty tomb.

Therefore:

Resurrection ≠ Spiritual Survival Alone

The empty tomb represents the earthly manifestation of Christ's victory over physical death.

Thus resurrection contains two dimensions:

Spiritual Victory

and:

Bodily Victory

or:

Spiritual Victory + Bodily Resurrection

16. DIVINE SPIRIT AND PHYSICAL DEATH

The proposed model distinguishes physical death from the cessation of Divine life.

The central distinction is:

Death of Earthly Body ≠ Death of Divine Life

Within Christian Christology, Jesus Christ is understood as Divine and human.

The proposed model therefore suggests that the death of Christ's earthly body did not mean the extinction of His Divine existence.

This distinction is important when discussing Christ's death and resurrection.

17. THE PROPOSED SPIRITUAL-BODY STATE

The distinctive hypothesis of this research concerns Christ's condition during physical death.

The model proposes:

Earthly Body → Physical Death

while:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

continues in spiritual existence.

The spiritual body is understood as corresponding to the earthly body:

Spiritual Body ~ Earthly Body

The spiritual body therefore functions within the model as a proposed continuity between earthly bodily identity and resurrection bodily identity.

18. IMPORTANT SCHOLARLY QUALIFICATION

This proposition must be stated carefully.

The Bible explicitly teaches that:

- Jesus died.
- Jesus was buried.
- Jesus was raised.
- Jesus appeared to His disciples.
- Jesus possessed bodily reality after resurrection.
- Paul speaks of a “spiritual body.”
- Paul speaks of the image of the earthly and the heavenly.
- Christ was not abandoned to Hades.

However, Scripture does **not explicitly state in these exact terms**:

“During the period in which His earthly body was dead, Jesus possessed a separate spiritual body corresponding to His earthly body.”

Therefore, this proposition should be classified as:

A THEOLOGICAL HYPOTHESIS

rather than:

AN EXPLICIT BIBLICAL STATEMENT

This distinction is necessary for academic integrity.

19. 1 PETER 3:18

1 Peter 3:18 provides an important passage:

Christ was “put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit.”

The Greek terminology contrasts:

σαρκί — *sarki*

“in flesh”

with:

πνεύματι — *pneumati*

“in spirit.”

The interpretation of this passage has been debated throughout Christian scholarship.

Nevertheless, the passage is relevant because it explicitly connects Christ's death in relation to the flesh with life in relation to the spirit.

It therefore provides conceptual support for distinguishing physical death from spiritual life.

However, it does not by itself prove the complete three-dimensional model proposed in this research.

20. CHRIST AND HADES

Acts 2:27–31, drawing upon Psalm 16, speaks of Christ not being abandoned to Hades and of His flesh not seeing corruption.

The Greek term:

ᾗδης — *Hades*

refers to Hades or the realm of the dead.

The passage therefore connects:

Christ + Death + Hades + Resurrection

Within the proposed model, Christ's victory over death can be understood as extending into the realm of death.

Nevertheless, the text should not be forced to provide details that it does not explicitly state.

Acts 2 does not directly present the complete formula:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body

That formula is a theological synthesis.

21. THE TWO-DIMENSIONAL VICTORY OF CHRIST

Pawan Upadhyay's proposed model understands Christ's victory in two dimensions.

21.1 Spiritual Victory

The model proposes:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body → Victory over Death/Hades

21.2 Earthly Victory

The earthly body is raised from the tomb:

Earthly Body → Resurrection

Therefore:

Victory Over Death = Spiritual Victory + Bodily Resurrection

This framework distinguishes Christ's victory in the spiritual realm from the physical manifestation of resurrection through the empty tomb.

22. THE THREEFOLD MODEL

The complete proposed model consists of three dimensions:

1. Divine Spirit

The Divine life of Christ.

2. Spiritual Body

A proposed spiritual mode of bodily existence corresponding to Christ's earthly bodily identity.

3. Earthly Body

Christ's incarnate human bodily existence.

The model is therefore:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body → Resurrected Christ

This formula should be understood as a theological model rather than as a literal mathematical equation.

23. STATE ONE: EARTHLY INCARNATE EXISTENCE

During earthly life, Christ possesses human bodily existence.

The incarnation can be represented conceptually as:

Divine Word + Human Nature

John 1:14 states that the Word became flesh.

Christ's earthly body is therefore integral to His incarnate existence.

24. STATE TWO: PHYSICAL DEATH

At physical death:

Earthly Body → Death

The proposed model distinguishes this from the cessation of Divine life:

Earthly Body dies ≠ Divine Life ceases

This distinction is central to the proposed framework.

25. STATE THREE: SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE

The model proposes that during physical death:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

continues in spiritual existence.

The spiritual body corresponds to the earthly body:

Spiritual Body ~ Earthly Body

This is the distinctive theological hypothesis of this research.

26. STATE FOUR: RESURRECTION

The resurrection is then conceptualized as the restoration and transformation of Christ's earthly bodily existence.

The model can be expressed:

(Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body) + Earthly Body → Resurrected Christ

The earthly body is no longer merely mortal.

It is transformed:

Mortal → Immortal

Perishable → Imperishable

Natural → Spiritual

Weakness → Power

Dishonor → Glory

27. STATE FIVE: GLORIFIED EXISTENCE

The resurrection is not simply a return to ordinary mortal life.

Rather:

Earthly Body → Glorified Resurrection Body

The risen Christ is therefore:

Continuous in Identity

and:

Transformed in Bodily Condition

This can be summarized:

Continuity + Transformation = Resurrection

28. DOES THE SPIRITUAL BODY MEAN A SECOND BODY?

This question requires careful consideration.

The model does not necessarily require two permanently independent bodies.

The terms “earthly body,” “spiritual body,” and “resurrection body” may be understood as describing different modes or states of bodily existence.

Therefore, the conceptual progression is:

Earthly Bodily Existence → Spiritual Bodily Existence → Glorified Bodily Existence

rather than:

Body A + Body B + Body C

The purpose of the model is to explain continuity of embodied identity rather than to multiply physical entities.

29. IMAGE DOES NOT NECESSARILY MEAN EXACT PHYSICAL DUPLICATION

The word “image” should also be interpreted carefully.

Image or likeness does not necessarily mean that every physical or molecular property is identical.

Rather, the proposed concept concerns:

- identity;
- likeness;
- correspondence;
- recognizable continuity;
- bodily relationship.

Therefore:

Image ≠ Exact Material Duplication

but:

Image = Correspondence/Likeness

This distinction allows the concept to remain theological rather than reducing it to a physical duplication theory.

30. RESURRECTION AND REINCARNATION

The proposed model should not be confused with reincarnation.

Reincarnation generally refers to another embodiment or another earthly life.

Resurrection refers to the raising of the dead person into renewed and transformed life.

Therefore:

Resurrection ≠ Reincarnation

The spiritual-body hypothesis does not require multiple earthly lives or successive earthly bodies.

Instead, it proposes continuity of the same Christ through death and resurrection.

31. RESURRECTION AND ASCENSION

Resurrection and ascension are distinct theological events.

Resurrection:

Death → Life

Ascension:

Risen Christ → Heavenly Exaltation

The present study primarily concerns:

Death → Resurrection

rather than the subsequent ascension.

32. THEOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE OF BODILY CONTINUITY

The proposed model has several theological implications.

32.1 Death does not destroy personal identity

Physical Death ≠ Loss of Personal Identity

32.2 The body remains theologically significant

The body is not merely temporary packaging for the spirit.

32.3 Resurrection is bodily

The risen Christ is presented as genuinely embodied.

32.4 Resurrection is transformative

The resurrection body is associated with glory, power, immortality, and imperishability.

32.5 Divine life triumphs over death

The resurrection demonstrates the triumph of life over death.

33. BIBLICAL EVIDENCE VERSUS THEOLOGICAL HYPOTHESIS

Proposition	Classification
Jesus Christ died	Explicit biblical teaching
Jesus was buried	Explicit biblical teaching
Jesus was raised	Explicit biblical teaching
Jesus appeared after resurrection	Explicit biblical teaching
Jesus possessed bodily reality after resurrection	Strongly presented in the Gospel narratives
Paul teaches a “spiritual body”	Explicit biblical teaching
Paul teaches earthly/heavenly image	Explicit biblical teaching
Christ was not abandoned to Hades	Biblical teaching
Christ was “made alive in spirit”	Biblical statement; interpretation debated

A spiritual body existed during Christ's physical death	Theological hypothesis
The spiritual body corresponds to the earthly body	Theological model
Christ's Divine Spirit re-entered His earthly body	Theological hypothesis
Resurrection unifies the three dimensions	Theological synthesis

This distinction should remain clear in all future presentations of the theory.

34. THE COMPLETE RESURRECTION MODEL

The proposed sequence can be summarized as follows:

Stage I — Incarnation

Divine Word + Human Earthly Body

Stage II — Death

Earthly Body → Physical Death

Stage III — Spiritual Existence

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

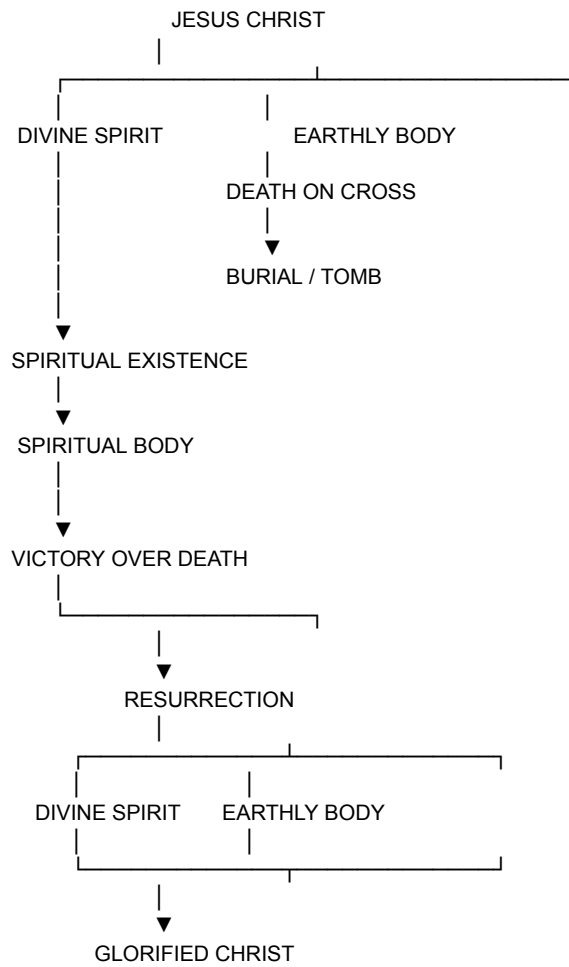
Stage IV — Resurrection

(Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body) + Earthly Body → Resurrected Christ

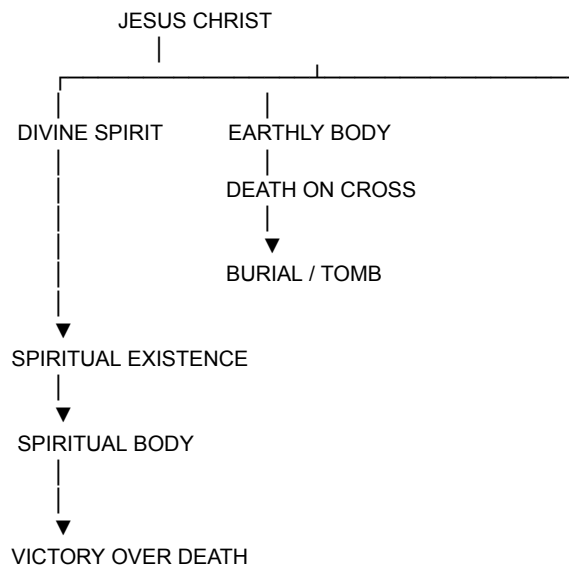
Stage V — Glorification

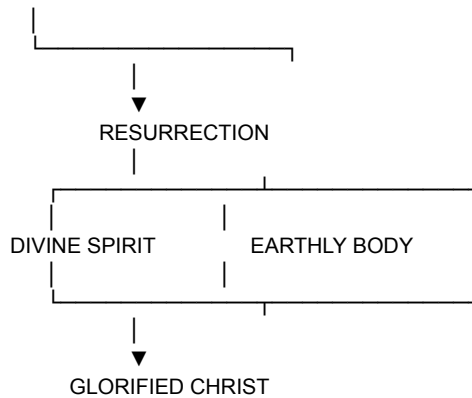
Resurrected Body → Glorified Resurrection Body

35. MASTER CONCEPTUAL DIAGRAM



2nd Diagram:





Central relationship:

Spiritual Body ↔ Earthly Body

The spiritual body is proposed to correspond to the earthly body in image, likeness, and identity.

36. THE RESURRECTION EQUATION

The model can be represented by the following conceptual equation:

$$\mathbf{R = DS + SB + EB}$$

where:

R = Resurrected Christ

DS = Divine Spirit

SB = Spiritual Body

EB = Earthly Body

More dynamically:

$$(\mathbf{DS + SB}) + \mathbf{EB} \rightarrow \mathbf{RG}$$

where:

RG = Glorified Resurrection Existence.

This equation is theological and conceptual, not a mathematical description of a physical mechanism.

37. THE IMAGE PRINCIPLE

The central relationship is:

SB ~ EB

where:

SB = Spiritual Body

EB = Earthly Body

~ = image, likeness, correspondence

Thus:

Spiritual Body = Bodily Identity in a Spiritual Mode

within the proposed theological model.

38. THREEFOLD CONTINUITY PRINCIPLE

The model can be summarized by three principles.

Principle 1 — Spiritual Continuity

Divine Life continues through physical death.

Principle 2 — Bodily Correspondence

The spiritual body corresponds to the earthly body.

Principle 3 — Resurrection Transformation

The earthly body is raised into transformed and glorified existence.

Together:

Continuity + Correspondence + Transformation = Resurrection Model

39. IMPLICATIONS FOR CHRISTIAN ANTHROPOLOGY

The model also raises important questions concerning human nature.

If resurrection involves a spiritual body rather than the elimination of embodiment, then Christian anthropology can maintain that the human person is not ultimately defined as spirit alone.

The resurrection hope includes bodily existence.

Therefore:

Human Person ≠ Spirit Alone

Rather:

Human Person → Transformed Bodily Existence

This is consistent with Paul's broader teaching concerning resurrection.

40. IMPLICATIONS FOR CHRISTOLOGY

The model also emphasizes the uniqueness of Jesus Christ.

Christian Christology understands Christ as both Divine and human.

Therefore:

Divine Word + Human Nature

The death and resurrection of Jesus Christ consequently have significance beyond an ordinary human resurrection.

Within the proposed model, Christ's resurrection represents the triumph of Divine life through human bodily existence.

41. THEOLOGICAL DISTINCTION BETWEEN SPIRIT, SPIRITUAL BODY, AND EARTHLY BODY

The three concepts should not be treated as identical.

Dimension	Concept
Divine Spirit	Source and continuity of Divine life
Spiritual Body	Proposed spiritual mode of bodily existence
Earthly Body	Incarnate human bodily existence
Resurrection Body	Transformed and glorified bodily existence

The distinction can be expressed:

Spirit ≠ Spiritual Body ≠ Earthly Body

while they are related within the proposed model.

42. THE ROLE OF PERSONAL IDENTITY

Personal identity is essential to resurrection.

If Jesus who died were not the Jesus who rose, resurrection would become replacement rather than resurrection.

The Gospel narratives instead present continuity.

Therefore:

The One Who Died = The One Who Rose

This supports the broader theological principle:

Resurrection preserves identity while transforming bodily condition.

43. THEOLOGICAL MODEL OF CHRIST'S VICTORY

The proposed model can therefore be expressed in two stages of victory.

Spiritual Realm

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body → Victory over Death

Earthly Realm

Earthly Body → Resurrection from the Tomb

Together:

Spiritual Victory + Bodily Resurrection = Complete Victory Over Death

This provides a framework for understanding resurrection as victory in both spiritual and bodily dimensions.

44. LIMITATIONS OF THE MODEL

Every theological model must recognize its limitations.

The present model does not claim that Scripture provides a detailed biological or metaphysical description of the spiritual body.

The New Testament does not explain:

- the physical composition of a spiritual body;
- the mechanism by which spiritual and bodily existence interact;
- whether a separate spiritual body exists during the intermediate state;
- how precisely Christ's Divine and human dimensions operate during death.

Consequently, these areas remain theological questions.

The model should therefore be regarded as:

A Proposed Theological Framework

rather than:

A Scientifically Demonstrated Physical Mechanism

or:

An Explicit Biblical Technical Definition.

45. CENTRAL THESIS

The central thesis of this research can be stated as follows:

The New Testament presents resurrection as both continuity and transformation. Paul's concept of the σῶμα πνευματικόν (“spiritual body”), together with his language concerning the image of the earthly and the heavenly, provides a conceptual framework for understanding resurrection as transformed bodily existence rather than merely disembodied survival. Within Pawan Upadhyay's proposed theological model, this continuity is further expressed through the proposition that the spiritual body is in the image or likeness of the earthly body.

46. CONCLUSIONS

The study produces the following conclusions.

Conclusion 1

The New Testament clearly teaches the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Death → Burial → Resurrection

Conclusion 2

The resurrection narratives present continuity between the crucified and risen Jesus.

Conclusion 3

Paul explicitly uses the expression:

σῶμα πνευματικόν — *sōma pneumatikon*

“spiritual body.”

Conclusion 4

“Spiritual body” should not automatically be interpreted as “bodyless spirit.”

Conclusion 5

1 Corinthians 15 connects resurrection transformation with the language of earthly and heavenly image.

Conclusion 6

The Gospel narratives strongly support the bodily identity of the risen Jesus.

Conclusion 7

The proposition that a spiritual body existed during the interval of Christ's physical death is not explicitly stated in Scripture.

Conclusion 8

The proposition that the spiritual body is “in the image of the earthly body” is therefore best classified as a theological synthesis based upon biblical concepts of bodily continuity, image, transformation, and resurrection.

Conclusion 9

The proposed model can be summarized:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body → Resurrected and Glorified Christ

Conclusion 10

The fundamental theological principle is:

Continuity + Transformation = Resurrection

47. FINAL THEOLOGICAL STATEMENT

Jesus Christ truly died in His earthly bodily existence, was buried, and was raised from the dead.

His resurrection was not the replacement of one identity by another, nor merely the survival of a disembodied spirit. The risen Christ remained the same Jesus who had been crucified, while His bodily existence was transformed into resurrection glory.

Within **Pawan Upadhyay's proposed theological model**, the spiritual body represents a mode of bodily existence corresponding to Christ's earthly bodily identity.

The Divine Spirit represents continuing Divine life.

The spiritual body represents the proposed continuity of bodily identity during spiritual existence.

The earthly body represents Christ's incarnate human bodily existence.

The resurrection represents the restoration and transformation of Christ's earthly bodily existence into glorified resurrection life.

Therefore:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body → Resurrected and Glorified Christ

The central principle is:

The spiritual body is proposed as being in the image and likeness of the earthly body, preserving bodily identity through the transition from earthly existence toward resurrection.

And the ultimate resurrection principle is:

Continuity + Transformation = Resurrection.

Thus, the resurrection of Jesus Christ may be understood as the ultimate triumph of Divine life over death through transformed and glorified bodily existence.

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John 20:1–29 — Resurrection and Thomas

Acts 2:22–32 — Resurrection and Hades

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1 Corinthians 15:3–58 — Resurrection and resurrection body

Ephesians 4:8–10 — Descent and ascent

Philippians 3:20–21 — Transformation of the body

1 Peter 3:18–20 — Death in flesh and life in spirit

Revelation 1:17–18 — Christ was dead and is alive forevermore

KEY GREEK VOCABULARY

Greek	Transliteration	Meaning
σῶμα	<i>sōma</i>	body
πνεῦμα	<i>pneuma</i>	spirit
πνευματικός	<i>pneumatikos</i>	spiritual
ψυχικός	<i>psychikos</i>	natural/soulish
ἀνάστασις	<i>anastasis</i>	resurrection
ἀνίστημι	<i>anistēmi</i>	rise, raise
ἐγείρω	<i>egeirō</i>	raise, awaken
νεκρός	<i>nekros</i>	dead
θάνατος	<i>thanatos</i>	death
ᾍδης	<i>Hades</i>	Hades, realm of the dead
εἰκών	<i>eikōn</i>	image, likeness

δόξα	<i>doxa</i>	glory
ἀφθαρσία	<i>aphtharsia</i>	incorruption
ἀθανασία	<i>athanasia</i>	immortality
ζωή	<i>zōē</i>	life

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Research Fields

Biblical Theology
Christology
Resurrection Studies
Greek and Ancient Biblical Languages
Theology of Spirit and Body

RESEARCH STATUS

This paper intentionally distinguishes three levels of interpretation:

LEVEL I — EXPLICIT BIBLICAL TEACHING

Death, burial, resurrection, bodily appearances, spiritual body, earthly/heavenly image.

LEVEL II — STRONG THEOLOGICAL INFERENCE

Continuity of Christ's personal and bodily identity through resurrection.

LEVEL III — PAWAN UPADHYAY'S PROPOSED THEOLOGICAL MODEL

The spiritual body corresponding to the earthly body during the interval of physical death, and the conceptual reunification of Divine Spirit, spiritual body, and earthly body in resurrection.

Therefore, the paper's distinctive proposition should be understood as a **theological hypothesis for further biblical and theological investigation**.

DIVINE SPIRIT + SPIRITUAL BODY + EARTHLY BODY → RESURRECTED CHRIST

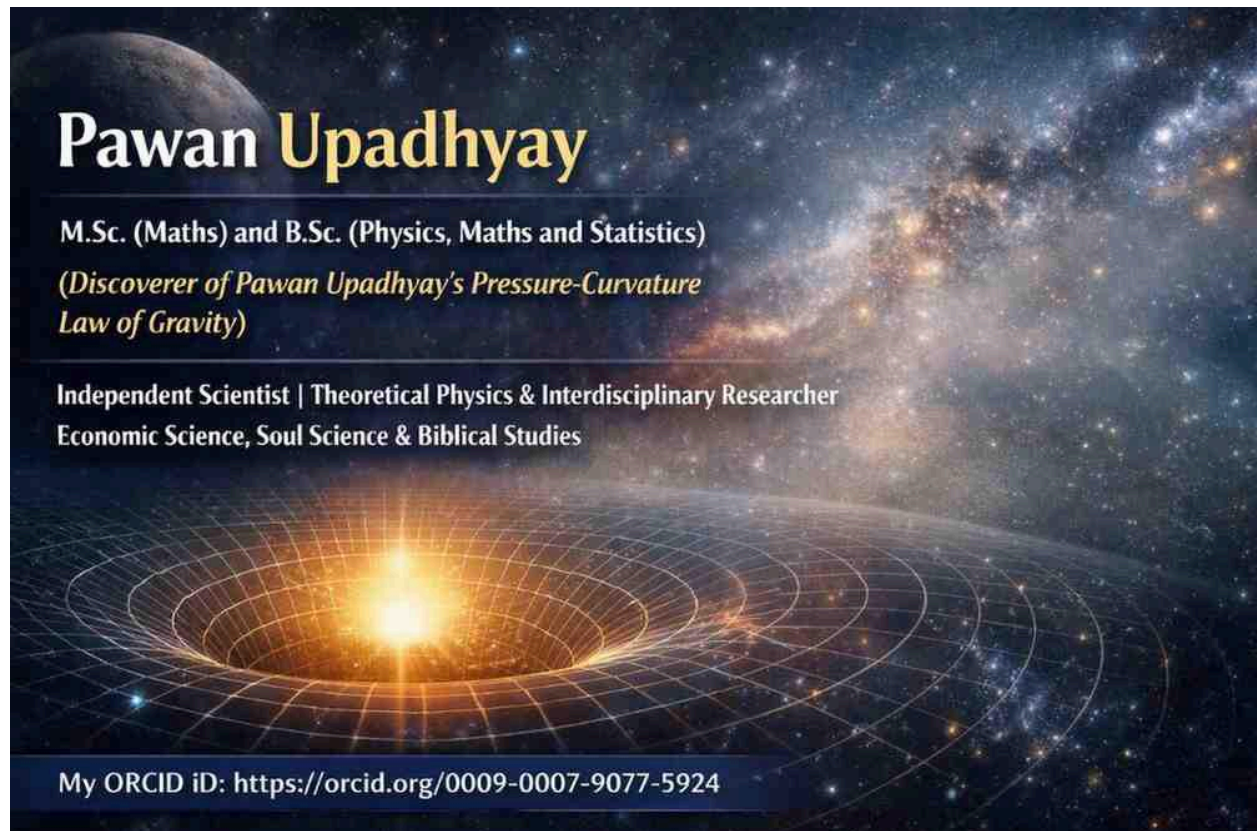
SPIRITUAL BODY ~ EARTHLY BODY

CONTINUITY + TRANSFORMATION = RESURRECTION

[Blog Version]

Pawan Upadhyay's View: The Resurrection of Jesus Christ — Spirit, Spiritual Body and Earthly Body

The Greatest Mystery of the Resurrection



Resurrection means rising from the dead.

For Christianity, the greatest example of resurrection is **Lord Jesus Christ**.

Jesus Christ died on the cross. He was buried. Yet death did not destroy Him.

According to the theological model proposed by **Independent Scientist and Independent Interdisciplinary Researcher Pawan Upadhyay**, the resurrection of Jesus Christ can be understood as a profound event involving **Divine Spirit, spiritual body, and earthly physical body**.

His central idea is that Jesus' resurrection was not simply the return of a dead physical body to ordinary life. Rather, it was the **unification of His Divine Spirit, spiritual body, and earthly body in glorified resurrection life**.

1. Jesus Christ Died on the Cross

The first event is the crucifixion.

Jesus Christ truly experienced physical death.

His earthly body died and was removed from the cross.

The Gospel accounts then describe His burial.

The apostolic proclamation summarized this sequence:

“He died ... he was buried ... he was raised on the third day.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:3–4

Therefore:

Cross → Death → Burial

But Pawan Upadhyay's model asks an additional question:

What happened to Christ's Spirit while His earthly body was in the tomb?

2. His Earthly Body Was in the Grave

After Jesus' death, His earthly body was placed in the tomb.

The tomb therefore represents the earthly location of Christ's dead body.

But death of the physical body does not necessarily mean destruction of spiritual existence.

Pawan Upadhyay proposes that:

Only Christ's earthly physical body died, while His Divine Spirit remained alive with a spiritual body.

Thus his model distinguishes between:

Earthly Physical Body

and

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

This distinction forms the foundation of his resurrection theory.

3. The Divine Spirit Remained Alive

According to this model, Jesus' physical death did not destroy His Divine Spirit.

The New Testament contains language that becomes important for this interpretation.

1 Peter 3:18 says that Christ was:

“put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit.”

This passage has been interpreted in different ways by Christian scholars, particularly concerning the following reference to the “spirits in prison.”

Nevertheless, it provides an important theological basis for considering a distinction between Christ's physical death and His spiritual existence.

Pawan Upadhyay interprets this distinction through the concept of:

4. Christ's Spiritual Body

Paul writes in 1 Corinthians 15:44:

“It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.”

The Greek expression is:

σῶμα πνευματικόν

sōma pneumatikon

meaning:

spiritual body.

For Pawan Upadhyay, this expression provides an important conceptual basis for investigating the possibility of spiritual embodiment.

His model proposes that Christ's Divine Spirit was associated with a spiritual body during the interval between His earthly death and bodily resurrection.

This should be understood as a **theological interpretation**, because the New Testament does not explicitly state that Jesus possessed a separate spiritual body during this interval.

5. Christ Entered the Realm of the Dead

The New Testament contains several passages that have traditionally been connected with Christ's descent to the dead.

Among them are:

- Acts 2:27–31
- 1 Peter 3:18–20

- Ephesians 4:8–10

Acts 2 speaks of Christ not being abandoned to **Hades**.

The Greek word is:

ᾍδης — Hades

which can refer to the realm of the dead.

Pawan Upadhyay's model interprets Christ's spiritual existence as extending into this realm.

Thus:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

↓

Realm of the Dead

6. Christ Conquered Hell

One of the central statements of Pawan Upadhyay's theory is:

“By His spiritual body, the Divine Spirit of Lord Jesus Christ conquered hell.”

This presents Christ's descent not as defeat but as **victory**.

Death could not imprison Christ.

The realm of the dead could not permanently hold Christ.

Christ's victory therefore extends beyond the earthly realm.

The theological sequence becomes:

Death → Descent → Victory

This concept has a long history within Christian theology, although the precise interpretation of the New Testament passages concerning Christ's descent remains debated.

7. The Third Day

Then comes the central event:

the third day.

The Christian proclamation says:

Christ was raised from the dead on the third day.

This is not simply the continuation of Christ's spiritual existence.

It is resurrection.

The One who died is the One who rose.

The One who was buried is the One who appeared alive.

The One who was crucified is the One who conquered death.

8. Spirit Returns to the Earthly Body

Here is the distinctive element of Pawan Upadhyay's model.

He proposes:

On the third day, the Divine Spirit of Jesus Christ, together with His spiritual body, returned to His earthly physical body.

In this interpretation, the resurrection involves the reunion of:

Divine Spirit

-

Spiritual Body

-

Earthly Physical Body



Resurrection of Jesus Christ

This is the central concept of the model.

Again, the precise statement that Christ's Spirit “re-entered” His earthly body is **not explicitly recorded in the New Testament**. It is the theological mechanism proposed by Pawan Upadhyay to explain the relationship between Christ's spiritual existence and His bodily resurrection.

9. Resurrection as Unification

According to this model, resurrection is fundamentally an event of **unification**.

Before death:

Divine Spirit + Earthly Body

During physical death:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

while:

Earthly Body → Tomb

On the third day:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body



Resurrected Christ

This gives the word **resurrection** a profound theological meaning.

It is not merely:

body comes back to life.

It is:

the restoration and transformation of the whole personal existence of Christ.

10. The Resurrected Body Was Not Ordinary Mortal Life

The risen Jesus was not simply returned to His former mortal condition.

His resurrection body was transformed.

Jesus could show His wounds to His disciples.

He could be touched.

He could eat.

Yet His resurrection life was no longer ordinary mortal existence.

Paul describes resurrection transformation:

Perishable → Imperishable

Weakness → Power

Natural body → Spiritual body

Mortality → Immortality

Therefore:

Resurrection is transformation, not merely resuscitation.

11. Jesus' Own Words

Jesus gave the deepest description of resurrection when He said:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

— John 11:25

This statement is extraordinary.

Jesus does not merely say that He will teach people about resurrection.

He says:

“I am the resurrection.”

Therefore, resurrection is inseparable from the person of Christ.

Christ is the source of resurrection life.

Christ is the conqueror of death.

Christ is the giver of eternal life.

12. Two Dimensions of Christ's Victory

Pawan Upadhyay's model therefore proposes two corresponding victories.

Spiritual Victory

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

↓

Realm of the Dead

↓

Victory over Hell/Death

Bodily Victory

Earthly Physical Body



Death



Resurrection



Victory over earthly death

Thus:

By His spiritual body, Christ conquered the realm of death; by His resurrected earthly body, Christ conquered death in the earthly realm.

13. From Earth to Heaven

The complete movement of Christ can therefore be represented:

Heaven



Incarnation



Earthly Life



Crucifixion



Death



Burial

↓

Spiritual Realm / Realm of the Dead

↓

Victory

↓

Third-Day Resurrection

↓

Glorified Body

↓

Ascension

↓

Heaven

The movement begins in heavenly glory and, through incarnation, enters the earthly realm.

Christ then passes through death.

Death cannot retain Him.

He rises.

He returns to heavenly glory.

14. Resurrection and Reincarnation

Pawan Upadhyay's broader framework also distinguishes spiritual resurrection from bodily resurrection and has used the concept of reincarnation in relation to spiritual resurrection.

Here an important distinction is necessary.

Reincarnation generally means repeated earthly embodiment.

Resurrection generally means being raised from death.

Christianity traditionally teaches resurrection rather than a cycle of reincarnation.

Therefore, when the term “**resurrection of spirit**” is used to describe reincarnation, it should be understood as **Pawan Upadhyay's proposed conceptual terminology**, not as the standard biblical definition of reincarnation.

15. The Great Mystery

The deepest question is not simply:

“Did Jesus rise?”

Christianity answers:

Yes.

The deeper question is:

“How should we understand the relationship between Christ's Spirit, His spiritual existence, His earthly body, His death, His resurrection, and His ascension?”

Pawan Upadhyay's model proposes an answer:

The death of Christ separated His earthly bodily existence from His spiritual existence temporarily; His spiritual existence continued with a spiritual body, His Divine Spirit conquered the realm of death, and on the third day His spiritual and earthly dimensions were reunited in resurrection life.

16. The Resurrection Formula

Pawan Upadhyay's theory can be summarized in one formula:

DIVINE SPIRIT

+

SPIRITUAL BODY

+

EARTHLY BODY

=

RESURRECTED CHRIST

And the two victories can be expressed:

SPIRITUAL BODY

→ **Victory over Hell / Realm of Death**

RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY

→ **Victory over Earthly Death**

GLORIFIED CHRIST

→ **Ascension into Heaven**

17. A Note of Scholarly Caution

This model should be understood as an **independent theological proposal**.

Several elements have strong biblical foundations:

- Jesus died.
- Jesus was buried.
- Jesus was raised on the third day.
- Jesus appeared bodily.
- Jesus' resurrection body was transformed.

- Jesus ascended into heaven.
- New Testament passages speak of Christ in relation to the Spirit and the realm of the dead.

Other elements are **interpretive propositions**, including:

- Christ having a distinct spiritual body during the interval of death;
- Christ conquering hell specifically through that spiritual body;
- Christ's Spirit and spiritual body re-entering His earthly body on the third day;
- defining resurrection as the unification of Divine Spirit, spiritual body, and earthly body.

These propositions require further investigation in biblical studies, Greek linguistics, historical theology, philosophy of religion, and comparative religious studies.

Conclusion

The resurrection of Lord Jesus Christ is the greatest mystery and the central victory of Christian faith.

Jesus died on the cross.

He was buried.

His earthly body entered the grave.

According to Pawan Upadhyay's proposed model, His Divine Spirit remained alive with a spiritual body.

The Divine Spirit with His spiritual body entered the realm of the dead and conquered hell.

On the third day, the Divine Spirit and spiritual body returned to and united with the earthly physical body.

The result was the **resurrection of Jesus Christ**.

The risen Christ then lived in glorified resurrection existence and ascended into heaven.

Therefore, the central proposition of this model is:

“The resurrection of Lord Jesus Christ was the unification of Divine Spirit, spiritual body, and earthly body.”

And its central declaration is:

“By His spiritual body, Divine Spirit conquered the realm of death; by the resurrection of His earthly body, Christ conquered earthly death.”

The final word belongs to Jesus Himself:

“I am the resurrection and the life.”

— John 11:25

Christ died.

Christ descended.

Christ conquered.

Christ rose.

Christ lives.

Christ reigns.

The Spiritual Body as the Image of the Earthly Body

A further principle in **Pawan Upadhyay’s proposed model of the resurrection of Jesus Christ** is that:

The spiritual body is in the image or likeness of the earthly body.

This principle is intended to explain the continuity of Christ’s personal identity through death, spiritual existence, and resurrection. The spiritual body is not understood as an unrelated or completely different form of existence, but as a spiritual mode of bodily existence corresponding to the earthly body.

Spiritual Body ~ Image/Likeness of Earthly Body

Here, “~” means **correspondence or likeness**, not necessarily physical identity.

1. Earthly Image and Heavenly Image

A significant biblical connection appears in Paul’s discussion of resurrection:

“As we have borne the image of the earthly, we shall also bear the image of the heavenly.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:49

Paul connects the **earthly image** with the **heavenly image** in the context of resurrection and transformation.

His argument develops a series of contrasts:

Earthly condition	Resurrection condition
Perishable	Imperishable
Dishonor	Glory
Weakness	Power
Natural body	Spiritual body
Earthly image	Heavenly image

Thus, resurrection does not mean the disappearance of personal identity. Rather, Paul describes a **transformation of bodily existence**.

2. “Spiritual Body” Does Not Mean “Bodyless Spirit”

Paul writes:

σπείρεται σῶμα ψυχικόν, ἐγείρεται σῶμα πνευματικόν

speiretai sōma psychikon, egeiretai sōma pneumatikon

“It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.”

— 1 Corinthians 15:44

The crucial word is:

σῶμα — sōma — body

Paul therefore does not simply contrast:

Body ➡ No Body

Instead, he contrasts:

Natural Body → Spiritual Body

The adjective **πνευματικόν** (*pneumatikon*), “spiritual,” modifies **σῶμα** (*sōma*), “body.”

Therefore, within this proposed model, “spiritual body” should not automatically be understood as “bodyless spirit.”

3. The Image Principle and Christ’s Identity

The resurrection narratives emphasize continuity between the crucified Jesus and the risen Jesus.

In **Luke 24:39**, Jesus says:

“A spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.”

He then eats before His disciples.

Similarly, in **John 20:27**, Thomas is invited to examine the wounds of the crucified and risen Christ.

These passages establish an important principle:

Crucified Jesus → Risen Jesus

The Jesus who was crucified is the Jesus who was raised.

Therefore, in Pawan Upadhyay’s proposed model, the spiritual body cannot represent a completely unrelated identity. It corresponds to the identity of the earthly Jesus.

4. The Threefold Resurrection Model

This principle can be incorporated into the larger model:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body = Resurrected Christ

The model can be represented in three stages.

Before death

Divine Spirit + Earthly Body

Christ possesses His earthly bodily existence.

During physical death

The earthly body dies:

Earthly Body → Death

while, according to the proposed model:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

continues in spiritual existence.

Resurrection

The model proposes:

[(Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body)] + Earthly Body

leading to the complete resurrected Christ.

Thus, resurrection is understood not merely as the continuation of the Spirit, but as the **reunification and transformation of bodily existence**.

5. Why the Image Principle Matters

The image principle helps explain three kinds of continuity:

Continuity	Meaning
Personal continuity	The same Jesus Christ remains the same person
Bodily continuity	Resurrection remains connected with His earthly body
Spiritual continuity	Divine life is not extinguished by physical death

The conceptual sequence is:

Earthly Body → Death → Spiritual Bodily Existence → Resurrection → Glorified Bodily Existence

6. Image and Likeness

The broader biblical language of **image and likeness** is also significant.

Genesis speaks of humanity being made in the **image and likeness of God**, while Paul speaks in 1 Corinthians 15 about bearing the **image of the earthly** and the **image of the heavenly**.

However, these passages should not be treated as though they provide a single technical definition of “spiritual body.”

The statement:

“The spiritual body is in the image of the earthly body”

is best presented as **Pawan Upadhyay’s theological model derived from the biblical pattern of bodily continuity and transformation**.

Scripture explicitly teaches resurrection, speaks of a **σῶμα πνευματικόν — spiritual body**, and presents the risen Christ as bodily recognizable.

The additional proposition that Christ possessed a spiritual body during the interval of His physical death is an **interpretive theological hypothesis**, rather than an explicit biblical statement.

7. Spiritual Victory and Earthly Victory

Within this framework, Christ’s resurrection can be understood in two dimensions:

Spiritual Victory + Earthly Victory

Spiritual victory

The Divine Spirit, understood in this model as existing with a spiritual body, overcomes the realm of death.

Earthly victory

Christ’s earthly body is raised from the tomb and transformed into resurrected, glorified existence.

Therefore:

Victory over Death = Spiritual Victory + Bodily Resurrection

The empty tomb is consequently not merely a symbol of spiritual survival. In this model, it represents the earthly manifestation of resurrection: **the body that died and was buried is no longer remaining in the tomb.**

8. Final Formulation

The principle may therefore be stated as follows:

The spiritual body is understood in Pawan Upadhyay's proposed resurrection model as corresponding to, and existing in the image or likeness of, the earthly body, thereby preserving personal and bodily identity through the transition from earthly existence to resurrection.

This should be clearly identified as a **theological hypothesis**, rather than presented as an explicit technical definition found in Scripture.

The central biblical sequence remains:

Death → Burial → Resurrection → Glorified Life

while the proposed model adds:

Divine Spirit ↔ Spiritual Body ↔ Earthly Body

The spiritual body corresponds to the earthly body, while the final resurrection brings Christ's existence into complete bodily and spiritual unity.

Conclusion

According to this proposed theological model, **the resurrection of Jesus Christ is not the abandonment of the body but the ultimate triumph of Divine life over death through transformed and glorified bodily existence.**

The spiritual body provides the proposed continuity between earthly bodily identity and resurrected bodily existence, while the resurrection of the earthly body manifests Christ's victory over physical death.

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body + Earthly Body → Resurrected and Glorified Christ